

Daily AI, Crypto & Tech Power Briefing

July 10, 2026 - Middle East Special

The Strait of Hormuz Is Becoming the Center of the U.S.-Iran Crisis

Today's Middle East story is not a clean ceasefire story. It is a pressure story: the U.S. wants Iran to publicly guarantee safe shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, while Iran wants to keep control over the waterway as leverage.

The key risk is that this becomes a stop-start conflict instead of a full peace deal. Even limited strikes can affect oil, shipping insurance, inflation expectations and U.S. domestic politics.

1. The U.S. wants Iran to publicly guarantee that Hormuz stays open

AP News · July 10, 2026

US demands Iran publicly state that Strait of Hormuz is open and Tehran won't attack ships anymore

The story

AP reports that senior U.S. officials are demanding Iran make a public statement that the Strait of Hormuz is open and that ships using the route will no longer be attacked. The demand comes after renewed strikes and ship attacks weakened the interim ceasefire between Washington and Tehran.

The background is simple but dangerous. The U.S. says Iranian hard-liners may be trying to sabotage the ceasefire, while Iran says activity in the strait rests exclusively with Tehran. Because around a fifth of traded oil and natural gas passes through Hormuz, this is not only a military issue. It is a global energy issue.

Why it matters

For the U.S., the immediate goal is deterrence. Washington wants Iran to understand that attacks on commercial shipping will bring consequences, but it also wants enough diplomacy left to avoid a bigger regional war.

For markets, the strait is the main pressure point. If ships cannot move safely, oil prices, freight costs and insurance premiums can rise quickly. That can feed into inflation and make central banks more cautious.

What to watch

- Whether Iran gives a public guarantee or keeps insisting that it controls the strait.
- Whether Oman, Qatar, Pakistan and Turkey can keep talks alive after the latest strikes.
- Whether shipping companies continue using southern routes through Omani waters to avoid Iranian control.

2. Analysts now worry about a sporadic U.S.-Iran war, not a clean ending

Le Monde · July 10, 2026

[Strait of Hormuz deadlock could lead Trump into sporadic war with Iran](#)

The story

Le Monde argues that the renewed U.S. and Iranian strikes have damaged hopes for a quick end to the crisis. The core problem is the same: Iran sees Hormuz as its strongest bargaining chip, while the U.S. refuses to accept Iranian control over an international shipping route.

The article also connects the war to U.S. politics. Trump is asking Congress for more defense money, including extra funds for the 2026 war effort, while Democrats and some Republicans worry about an unpopular conflict before the midterm elections.

Why it matters

The phrase to remember is sporadic war. That means the conflict may not become a full invasion or a clean peace agreement. Instead, it could become repeated strikes, retaliation, stalled talks and temporary market shocks.

This is politically sensitive for Washington because Middle East wars are expensive and unpopular. If oil prices rise again, the conflict can quickly become a domestic inflation story, not only a foreign policy story.

What to watch

- Whether Congress supports Trump's additional war funding request.
- Whether new strikes remain limited or begin hitting more important Iranian infrastructure.
- Whether oil markets stay calm or begin pricing in a longer Hormuz crisis.

3. Trump's Gaza peacekeeping plan is starting much smaller than promised

The Wall Street Journal · July 9, 2026

Trump Wanted 20,000 Peacekeeping Troops in Gaza. He Is Starting With 10 to 20.

The story

The Wall Street Journal reports that Trump's Gaza peace plan aimed for about 20,000 international peacekeepers, but the first step may involve only 10 to 20 Moroccan troops training near Gaza rather than entering the territory.

The larger problem is implementation. Gaza still needs security, governance and reconstruction, but Hamas has not disarmed, international troop commitments are slow, and regional crises in Iran and Lebanon are pulling attention away from Gaza.

Why it matters

This matters because ceasefires are only the first layer of peace. If there is no credible security force, no trusted local governance and no reconstruction path, Gaza can remain unstable even after large-scale fighting slows.

For U.S. policy, the gap between 20,000 promised troops and 10 to 20 starting troops shows how hard it is to turn a diplomatic plan into a real mission. Countries may support stabilization in theory but hesitate when the security risk is real.

What to watch

- Whether more countries commit troops or funding to the International Stabilization Force.
 - Whether Hamas agrees to hand governance to a technocratic council and whether it faces pressure to disarm.
 - Whether Gaza reconstruction funding increases beyond partial commitments from Gulf states.
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Useful terms

ceasefire - 停火	interim deal - 临时协议
public guarantee - 公开保证	commercial shipping - 商业航运
shipping lane - 航运通道	choke point - 咽喉要道
energy security - 能源安全	deterrence - 威慑
retaliation - 报复 / 反击	bargaining chip - 谈判筹码
sporadic war - 零星战争 / 间歇性战争	escalation risk - 升级风险
war funding - 战争拨款	defense budget - 国防预算
insurance premium - 保险费溢价	inflation pressure - 通胀压力
peacekeeping troops - 维和部队	stabilization force - 稳定部队
technocratic council - 技术官僚委员会	reconstruction funding - 重建资金
regional spillover - 地区外溢影响	back-channel diplomacy - 秘密外交渠道

Today's big picture

The big picture is that the U.S. is trying to manage two very different Middle East problems at the same time: stopping the Iran conflict from damaging global shipping, and turning the Gaza ceasefire into a real security and governance plan.

The risk is that both problems become long, messy and expensive. If Hormuz remains uncertain and Gaza stabilization stays weak, markets and governments may treat the Middle East as a persistent source of inflation, energy and security risk.